Social partnership in VET in the Southern and Eastern Mediterranean region

Conclusions of the Regional Conference
18-19 July 2011, Turin

Social partners from 9 countries of the Southern and Eastern Mediterranean region met for the first time to discuss their involvement in vocational education training (VET), more specifically in continuing vocational training (CVT).

1. Plenary sessions

The presentation of the project concept was followed by EU countries examples on how social partners have used collective bargaining and social dialogue as tools to promote training. They have roles in funding and governance of training at different levels. They take part in forecasting of skill needs and provide guidance and counselling to their members.

A good practice on funding has been presented by Employers and Trade Unions representatives (*Confindustria* and *CGIL*, respectively) from the Piemonte region, Italy.

2. The outcomes of the workshops

Participants identified two main pillars of argumentation for social partners to be involved in CVT: Economic pillar linked to competitiveness and performance of enterprises. Training for skills development can support sustainability and growth of companies, which will be the main source of employment in future. The social pillar stresses the need for workers and job seekers to acquire skills required in the labour market. Training can support social cohesion, possibilities of individuals for skills development (decent work agenda -ILO), and workers mobility for a functioning labour market. Three building blocs have been identified as key components of CVT:

Governance: Good governance allows more efficient and transparent management of the training provision which is needed to improve performance of training institutions in order to meet labour market needs.

Financing: Should support companies, workers and job seekers to engage in skills development. Current funding systems and their management are considered inefficient to meet labour market needs.

Tools and mechanisms: There is a need to identify and develop competencies and qualifications that are more in line with labour market needs. This will require development of tools and mechanisms for skills need analysis and for collecting information about the needs for CVT and in labour market in general.

2.1. Arguments to justify institutional engagement in CVT

Participants split in two groups, employers and trade unions, to work on defining the role that social partners in the region could play in CVT and on building arguments for their organisations to be involved.

Employers

1.- Employers need to reinforce their capacities to develop human resources. They need also to provide argumentation on the importance of competitiveness for job creation. CVT is a key issue for maintaining and fostering companies' competiveness.

2.- In principle, CVT should be companies' responsibility and government bodies should take care of IVET (initial VET). Mismatch of skills is an issue when the learning outcomes don't meet the labour market needs. Basic education, IVET and academic education should support the enterprises and private sector.

3.- Experience from Maghreb countries revealed that funding of CVT based on levies is not functioning properly as enterprises are contributing but not participating in decision making. Funds are managed by governments which have different priorities than those of enterprises. Main issues about funding lie not on how to collect taxes and levies but on how to use them and on the lack of transparency of its distribution.

4.- Employers may be sceptical to involve themselves in training issues because they fear that the trade unions ask for a wage increase. Training issue could be tackled more successfully if it is not linked to a wage issue. On the other hand employers and enterprises need to provide better working conditions and career paths for those who are better qualified after participating in trainings.

5.- One way of going forward with training is to use pilot sectors in which the employers develop activities in the field of training. Good practises and successful achievements can later be transferred to other sectors.

6.- Big enterprises and SMEs have different capacities to be involved in training issues. The big ones can have their own training centres whereas SMEs often lack financial and/or human resources to organise training. Another aspect to take into account is the motivation of employers to engage in training courses that is partly linked to their capacities and their capacities are linked to the economic performance of the country. SMEs are in need of motivation and support.

7.- The expenditure of enterprises in training courses is not perceived as an investment that will bring short-term return by having more qualified workers. This is the case especially for subcontractors that are not interested in skills development of workers.

8.- When people learn only "by doing" they can learn wrong methods or wrong ways of working. There is also a need to learn away to change old habits and methods of work.

Trade Unions

Argumentation by the trade unions is built on needs to secure the career of employees, promote enterprise competitiveness, employability, social cohesion and equal opportunities which can be supported by CVT. For the unions the social pillar of training is important but they also recognise the value of training for economic development, competitiveness, jobs sustainability and career development opportunities for employees.

1.- Employability is a key issue both for unemployed and for employed people. For those that are employed career security and mobility in the labour market are of how high importance. Special focus should be made on youth, women, employees working in companies going through sectoral restructuration and those working in the informal sector to facilitate their access/insertion to the labour market.

2.- Training can promote economic and social equality when it provides access to the labour market and workforce increase.
3.- Reinforcement of the social partners' role to be involved in employment policy making processes.
4.- The right to lifelong learning (LLL) to be enhanced to reach the above mentioned targets.
5.- Trade unions need to work together in defining concepts of partnership and in establishing lines of action that can support employment creation. This is also linked to competitiveness of enterprises.
6.- Social partners need capacity building so that they can be involved in governance systems on continuing training including mechanisms of financing.
7.- Sustainability of companies is crucial for employment. Improvement of working conditions including health and safety at work is also needed and can be supported by training.

2.2.- Processes to develop CVT inside the institution

The second working group session concentrated on designing a process to develop a CVT agenda inside employer organisation and trade unions.

Employers

Employers defined six priority areas of common interest. They also shared their specific needs based on the level of cooperation and dialogue between trade unions and employers in their own countries:

1.- Focus on priority sectors that have a best potential to promote economic growth and employment.
2.- Analysis of labour market needs. CVT scope in a LLL context in the country should be defined.
3.- Enhancing social dialogue between employers and trade unions to be in a better position to influence policy making and governance of CVT and between social partners and ministries and other public authorities as the basis of a fruitful mutual work.
4.- Development of a strategic action plan (including an operational approach) to meet local labour market needs that contemplates skills needs required with special attention to those for SMEs. Beneficiaries would be companies, trainers, trainees and society in general. The strategy should take into consideration also unemployed people.
5.- Focus on institutions with whom social partners can work and which need to improve their performance.
6.- Legislation should be developed/updated to foster dialogue. In some countries legislation exists but hasn't been designed in collaboration with social partners.

Trade Unions

Trade unions considered that having vision and establishing a strategy is not enough but that they have to be involved in the implementation of training issues. They proposed the following six points in order to achieve its involvement:

1.- Analyse the existing situation on provision of training looking at the gaps and labour market needs. Special attention should be paid to the informal sector and SMEs where very often the rate of affiliation is very low. This will require analysis of the trade unions' internal organisation to see membership needs.
2.- Trade unions should pass from an angular to a central position in VET policy making processes and this demands "machinery" for partnership. Trade unions' rights need to be recognised and respected and as a social partner they must be represented at different levels of governance in VET and in labour market systems. Social partners should avoid situations where governmental institutions may tend to isolate them or create conflicting situations among themselves.

3.- Make VET a priority for trade unions by presenting to the leaders policy papers and action plans adopted in trade unions' conferences. This will help raise awareness of the importance of training.
4.- Make a strategy for collective bargaining and social dialogue which are the major tools for trade unions. Define what can be achieved in bipartite collective bargaining and what needs to be tackled in (tripartite) social dialogue.
5.- Raise awareness amongst militants at different levels of trade unions of understand the role and importance of VET by organising seminars and training sessions. Training should cover at least CVT/TVET, labour market analysis and negotiation skills.
6.- Focus on motivation of individuals and SMEs.

3. How will we work together on continuing training?

Mutual learning component (regionally)

Continuing training (CVT) was confirmed the focus of mutual learning within the project. There is still need to elaborate definitions that are relevant in the context of the countries. Therefore, definition, concepts and the use of a common language were identified to be important.

At a regional level, mutual learning includes study visits, regional annual events and two methodological notes to support the work of the social partners in participating countries and a mapping of their involvement in CVT. The annual regional conferences will provide the opportunity to share good practices and to learn from each other.

One of the deliverables will be a regional mapping of social partners' involvement in CVT in the countries of the region. All participating countries are expected to contribute to mapping. For this the ETF project team will prepare an analytical framework /questionnaire that will be sent to national participants in the autumn of 2011. The outcomes of the mapping as well as other activities at national level will be presented in the next regional conference in 2012.

National component

The conference ended with country sessions where country participants discussed with ETF country managers and the project team practical implementation issues of the project in the countries. Awareness raising and working together are important issues for all the countries. The first national activities that were discussed were based on capacity building. Discussion on the topics and activities for autumn 2011 was held only with 4 out of the 8 countries invited as the other 4 had only one social partner institution present in conference.

A first challenge at the national level is engagement of partners. Therefore, increase of partner members' participation is of high importance in order to build on capacity to work together[1].

The second challenge is to identify a common issue or theme to be tackled in the context of this project. This theme can be linked to an ongoing initiative or activities.

[1] Some country representatives missing and/or still to be identified

Table1: Result from country sessions of the first regional conference.

Country	Theme and activities	Steps
Algeria	Theme: looking at present legislation guiding CVET in relation with setting-up of the new VET Council. Visit with CAP and UGTA the new President of the VET Council to present the project and decide priorities. Meeting with other employers associations	To be decided after meeting other employers
Egypt	In absence of TU, theme was not identified. Socio-political situation in the country is difficult. Need for capacity building in 2012	Awareness raising
Israel	In absence of TU, theme was not identified. Cooperation between TUs and Employers is possible to be developed. Employers will start mapping one/two sectors to identify CVT needs and then pilot the development of training plans/interventions in partnership with MoiTAL and Histadrut.	Awareness raising and working together
Jordan	Theme not identified in absence of employers.	?
Lebanon	In the absence of TU, theme was not decided. Both National employer organisation (ALI: Association Libanaise des Industrialistes) and sectoral employer organisation (Agro-Food) have committed to participate in activities organised in the country. In case the TU accepts to be involved in the project, a social partners' workshop will be organised in the second half of October.	Awareness raising
Morocco	CGEM, UMT and UGTM will report to their organisations about this project and disseminate results of the conference. They will also identify members who will be involved in the project activities. They ask ETF support in commenting national VET strategy. Over the three years social partners basically expect to train together specialised CVT teams	Awareness raising and working together + Mapping and framework of cooperation
OPT	Theme: First steps towards joint position paper and cooperation at territorial level. Bipartite workshop in September.	Awareness raising and working together
Syria	Theme not identified in the absence of TU and the situation in Syria.	Awareness raising
Tunisia	Theme: Partnership on developing the territorial approach and sector projects. Workshops to be discussed with UTICA/UGTT and organised after the elections.	Awareness raising and working together

4. Roadmap for next three year

2011

- The first regional conference, Turin July
- A study visit for Maghreb countries, Autumn
- Analytical framework for the mapping prepared by ETF to be sent to participants
- Drafting of methodological note by ETF
- Activities in participating countries with the support of ETF project team and country managers
  - Definition of framework for cooperation
  - First elements of mapping

2012

- A study visit for Mashrek countries, spring
- Advisory Expert Committee meeting
- Second regional conference, Autumn
- First draft methodological note 1, Autumn
- First draft of mapping: Autumn
- Regional capacity building actions, autumn 2012-spring 2013
- Activities in participating countries with the support of ETF project team and country managers

2013

- Advisory Expert Committee meeting
- Third and final regional conference, 2013
- Finalisation of the second methodological note, autumn 2013
- Regional mapping of social partners involvement in CVT activities in participating countries, to complement the ETF study
- Roadmap for country support 2013 onwards

Exchange of information and networking within this project is supported by virtual a platform that was presented to participants. The platform is expected to be fully functional early 2012.

Next practical steps for the ETF project team

The ETF project team will start working with the following topics to implement the project together with national participants:

1. Preparation of the first methodological note to be presented in the next regional conference in 2012.
2. Preparation of an analytical framework/questionnaire for mapping social partners initiatives to be involved in CVT in the countries.
3. Preparation of the study visits for Maghreb (end 2011) and Mashrek (early 2012).

Organization and implementation of events/support agreed in country sessions of the conference.

Composition of the AEC

Two members of the participating countries have been nominated to be members of the AEC. Participants elected Mr Slassi (MOR) member, and Mr Zakhary (EGY) as alternate to represent employers and Mr Mongi (TUN) to represent trade unions in AEC. The alternate for trade unions from the Mashrek will be nominated later on.

Picture 1: Architecture of the project

